soldiers would be happy to be led by inexperienced or 'just-adequately exercised' leaders, who might be something akin to an untested missile! If we consider our lives as precious, so do the officers and men whom we have the privilege to lead in peace and war. The soldiers are the best judges of their leaders and we have the world's finest soldiers. Therefore, we as their commanders are honour bound to give them the leadership that they expect and that cannot happen without a rock-solid foundation based on command experience.

I commanded two battalions for a total period of over four-and-a-half years, the first tenure as a lieutenant colonel and the second in the rank of a colonel. Not that I was given a choice, but in retrospect, I believe it did give me sound command experience. Further, this is not to suggest that everything was always 'hunky dory'; things did go wrong, but it was my constant endeavour to do the assigned tasks sincerely, honestly and with a sense of commitment, and I did not shirk responsibility for things that went awry.

In order to win a war, we require the best leaders, or at least better leaders than our adversaries. When speaking on the wireless, the code word for a commander is 'tiger'. It implies that he has to lead his men like a tiger. More importantly, he shouldn't acquiesce before his superiors and become a 'yes man', or what is worse, a doormat; that would qualify him to be called a 'mouse'! There are some leaders who are the 'half-tiger–half-mouse' type. These are the guys who pose as tigers in front of their men, and behave as mice with their bosses. But sooner or later they get found out. I recall that when I was commanding the battalion at Tezu, the brigade commander inspected the unit and commented on a few issues regarding administration, documentation and other procedures in a five-page demi-official letter. Unfazed, I examined all the issues and while accepting full responsibility for the lapses, I replied that corrective measures would be taken expeditiously and ended the letter by stating unequivocally that, *'This is to assure you, Sir, that there can be no one more concerned about the operational and administrative efficiency of this battalion than me.'* By writing so